FIGURE AND GROUND

Odysseus. The Siren. An Attempt.

The Song of the Siren

In the weaker moments of our meandering lives, we tend to feel an urge at last to claim what we believe has long been owed to us since the days of our dreamy youth, yet withheld by fate. Out of sheer abandon we begin to expose ourselves to forces which – once unleashed – we can hardly rein in, and which – should we eventually escape the grinding struggle with them – leave their mark on us forever. We undo ourselves because we are convinced of our own resolve and believe we could hold our ground even in a heroic epic.

Like every human failing, this above all finds its ultimate expression in the figure of the wily Odysseus. In the uneventful interval after his descent into Hades and before Scylla and Charybdis loomed on the horizon, he saw fit, on a whim, to cast all caution to the wind and expose himself to that which had nearly brought the Argonauts' voyage to grief. Steeled by countless battles, with the self-assurance of a man whose ingenious stratagems had never yet failed, he thought it a small thing to resist the song of fabled creatures whose menace seemed, at best, containable. He meant to dispel any lingering doubts by having himself bound to the ship's central mast. His crew, however, he ordered to stop their ears with wax, so that they might go about their work undisturbed during the anticipated spectacle. And so Odysseus's ship approached the island where the singers were presumed to dwell: a row of shielded, industrious souls beside a body in chains.

When the men broke them, they mocked him for his laments. Nothing at all, they said, had occurred as they sailed past the island. No time now to squander on grief, the strait between the vortex and the monster looming near. Neither song nor inferno had they perceived. No rift had appeared, no draw had been unleashed. Nothing had happened worth dwelling upon.

It dawned on Odysseus that the pain had not only been inflicted but lay buried deep within him; that he would remain alone with it for all time. Even when the wandering years were over, when he had freed Penelope from her suitors and reclaimed his place at her side on the throne of Ithaca, it came back. Every spring anew.

Tender goes the night, like a consort to the furtive pair just stepping onto the celestial stage in the east. Ruby-red, Mars pierces the midnight-blue velvet, soon outshone by opalescent Venus; already, though, their presence fades in the transfiguring blue of the awakening day, which swiftly traverses the firmament and at last, far in the west, releases even Orion until evening.

Where the planet hunter withdrew, the boundaries between the states of the world still blur in this early hour, and only the gently stirring reflection of each in the other hints at that threshold where the elements part. From there, still several stadia distant, two points emerge, tumbling one around the other like animate sparks, gaining colour and form at breathtaking speed — like projectiles clad in orange and blue piercing the dawning day.

The sea lies beneath the hurtling flight as though removed from time, a longship as though frozen, passed in a heartbeat by the kingfisher pair. The sails are stowed, for Aeolus has held the winds; the rowing benches so still, as though someone had sat down to attend a performance. Swiftly the scene detaches from the ship, for on goes the halcyon chase across the calm sea towards the coastline, behind which the sun conceals itself before mounting once more to reclaim the sky.

As the coast draws near, the sea rises and falls more perceptibly, like the chest of a slumbering titan. The two take up its rhythm in flight, plunging beak-first, again and again, into the swell, as a salute to the daughters of Nereus, who attend the spectacle from the ocean floor in rapture. Daringly, just before the cliff face, they turn heavenward without losing their momentum, traversing with masterful ease the pillars of luminous white stone whose filigree might have inspired the flying buttresses of ambitious cathedrals, conceived by master builders of ages yet to come.

High above, the arches grow lighter, giving way at last to an open, gently rising plateau — a natural pasture where creatures slowly venture out in the half-light of early morning. The meadow still lies under silvery mist, swept away the next moment towards the cliff's edge with a roguish wink of the rising sun. Rich, nourishing green comes into view, speckled with luminous islands of wildflowers. At the foremost edge, as though suspended, a delicate being appears, its shadow cast by the low sun far out across the sea, past the ship on the horizon. Upright, her countenance turned to the sea, a woman stands, lips parting gently in time with the soft movement of her body. The woman sings. She sings a faery song.

She calls from another world. Desire made sound. Fulfilled longing. Keys of bliss. She stands there, merely singing, flooding him with surging sensation whose force he could not have fathomed. And as he becomes aware that he cannot follow, it turns to a torrent of all the noise that has filled the earth since the beginning of time. Shredded time. Distorted space. An engulfing anomaly robs him of the air he needs to scream. Tears the skin from his flesh, the flesh from his bones. Takes all his entrails and finally his heart. All that remains is his ravaged mind, robbed of everything that could give expression to the pain. The screams no one heard have long since faded. The chains hold.

All in this world is suffused with song and rises within it. As though the plateau drew its grandeur from its swell, the coastline its stature, as though in its wake the sea grew milder, the sky vaster, and even the sun in its majesty less stern than gentle. As though it dipped the grasses in a deeper green, lent the blossoms warmer colours, made the sheep meeker, the lambs more daring, the kingfishers more exuberant still. A song like balm, to which all things open — enlivened, heartened, heard; that could redeem sweet daydreams from their transience and shape them into substance. Music whose mighty waves of resonance could press even the fiercest daemons within into a buoyant dance. What force might it unleash where longings lie in chains, where the lonely crave companions, the unloved requital, the misunderstood an echo? Nothing can withstand this power. Nothing escape it. Nothing reach it. As long as she sings, the Siren is the most beautiful of all beings.

The world listens, but has no answer to give. No echo of all that resonance has ever reached its creatrix. Nor will it now. Long before the apple left the hand of Eris, the Siren set to music how solitude had become her mute companion. She composed songs of poets denied their silence, though they remained unread for all their lives; of dancers whose graceful movements only their own mirror was permitted to enjoy; of painters whose stirring works faded unseen on dusty floors. Songs of beings woven into song, singing because they must, even though it cannot change what is, nor end the isolation, nor ease the sadness, nor draw the thorn. All day long her song carries the world, pervades sky and sea, cliff and plain, plant and creature; not until evening does one solitary tear escape her, mirroring the setting sun's last glow.

Night falls like a curtain. The sea lies motionless, the ship barely advanced, the rowing benches orphaned. Strangely mechanical, as though drawn on winches, the kingfishers return to the west, where for one last breath the solitary Mercury pierces the dome of the sky, then they are gone with him. The world is silence.